Pre-Authorisation Requirement Matrix

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS
OPERATIONS POLICY AND PROCEDURE MANUAL
SECTION 4: UTILIZATION MANAGEMENT AND PRE-AUTHORIZATION
DOCUMENT ID: POL-UM-402-B
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4.1 Purpose and Scope

4.1.1 This policy establishes mandatory pre-authorization requirements, approval turnaround windows, required clinical documentation, and designated appeal routes for outpatient procedures performed across all 14 Meridian Health Partners clinic sites.

4.1.2 Compliance with this policy is mandatory for all attending physicians, referring providers, and scheduling personnel. Failure to secure pre-authorization prior to service delivery shall result in administrative denial of claims and a strict prohibition against balance-billing the patient, pursuant to Section 4.9 of the Meridian Provider Agreement.

4.2 Plan Definitions

4.2.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Premium commercial plan featuring broad network access and the lowest utilization thresholds.

4.2.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Standard commercial plan featuring moderate utilization controls and standard referral requirements.

4.2.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: High-deductible commercial plan featuring strict utilization management and mandatory step-therapy protocols.

4.2.4 CIVIC-BASE: Public-option managed care plan administered by Meridian under municipal contract, adhering to statutory pre-authorization mandates.

4.3 Procedure Pre-Authorization Schedule

4.3.1 Diagnostic Lumbar Spine Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, and CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: Standard processing shall be completed within 3 business days; urgent requests shall be completed within 24 hours. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Physician progress notes documenting at least 6 weeks of conservative therapy, physical therapy logs, and absence of red-flag neurological deficits. 4. Appeal Route: Tier-1 Physician Reconsideration via the Meridian Utilization Review Committee, followed by an independent external review through Apex Medical Review Panel if upheld.

4.3.2 Elective Diagnostic Knee Arthroscopy 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD; required under MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, and CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: 5 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Weight-bearing bilateral plain radiographs obtained within the last 180 days, specialist consultation notes, and documentation of mechanical locking or giving way. 4. Appeal Route: Peer-to-Peer consultation with Dr. Aris Thorne, Chief Medical Officer, followed by binding arbitration under the Meridian Member Grievance Board.

4.3.3 Outpatient Colonoscopy with Biopsy (Diagnostic/Symptomatic) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD and MERIDIAN-SILVER; required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE and CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: 2 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Detailed gastrointestinal history, documentation of specific alarm symptoms (e.g., unexplained weight loss, hematochezia), and referring provider risk stratification assessment. 5. Appeal Route: Fast-track clinical review by the Regional Medical Director, Dr. Sarah Lin, with secondary appeal to the State Insurance Commissioner's External Review Bureau.

4.3.4 Bariatric Surgery (Roux-en-Y Gastric Bypass) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, and CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: 10 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Comprehensive multidisciplinary evaluation including six-month medically supervised weight loss program logs,

psychological clearance evaluation, and registered dietitian nutritional assessment. 4. Appeal Route: Multidisciplinary Bariatric Appeals Panel, with final external appeal adjudicated by the National Healthcare Review Council.

4.3.5 Sleep Study (Polysomnography - In-Facility) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE and CIVIC-BASE; not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD and MERIDIAN-SILVER. 2. Approval Window: 3 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Completed Berlin Questionnaire or STOP-BANG score of 5 or greater, Epworth Sleepiness Scale score exceeding 12, and physical examination notes detailing Mallampati airway classification. 4. Appeal Route: Utilization Review Nurse Supervisor administrative review, escalating to the Meridian Clinical Quality Committee.

4.3.6 Non-Emergency Polypectomy (Dermatology) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE, provided lesion is documented as benign on visual inspection. Required for all plans if lesion is clinically suspicious and requires histopathological excision exceeding 2.0 centimeters. 2. Approval Window: 2 business days when applicable. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Dermatoscopic photographic documentation, anatomical site mapping, and preliminary clinical impression. 4. Appeal Route: Expedited Medical Director Review, with secondary appeal to the Patient Advocacy Office.

4.3.7 Diagnostic Upper Gastrointestinal Endoscopy (EGD) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE and CIVIC-BASE; not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD and MERIDIAN-SILVER. 2. Approval Window: 3 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Documentation of refractory dyspepsia unresponsive to an 8-week trial of high-dose proton pump inhibitor therapy, and relevant laboratory panels. 4. Appeal Route: Tier-1 Internal Clinical Review, followed by Independent Medical Examination (IME) coordinated through the Meridian Compliance Department.

4.3.8 Total Hip Arthroplasty 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, and CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: 7 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Kellgren-Lawrence grade 3 or 4 radiographic osteoarthritis confirmation, formal physical therapy records spanning a minimum of 12 weeks, and functional

disability scoring via the Western Ontario and McMaster Universities Osteoarthritis Index (WOMAC). 4. Appeal Route: Orthopedic Specialty Peer Review Board, chaired by Dr. Marcus Vance, with final appeal to the State Health Operations Tribunal.

4.3.9 Carpal Tunnel Release Surgery 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE and CIVIC-BASE; not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD and MERIDIAN-SILVER. 2. Approval Window: 4 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Electromyography (EMG) and nerve conduction velocity (NCV) test results confirming moderate-to-severe median nerve entrapment, plus documented failure of nocturnal splinting for at least 90 days. 4. Appeal Route: Neurology/Orthopedic Joint Review Panel, followed by external arbitration through Veritas Healthcare Arbitrators.

4.3.10 Diagnostic Electroencephalogram (EEG - Routine Outpatient) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: N/A (Exempt from pre-authorization). 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Order from a licensed neurologist or attending physician containing explicit diagnostic ICD-10 indication codes. 4. Appeal Route: N/A.

4.3.11 Outpatient Physical Therapy (Visits 1 through 12) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Not required under MERIDian-GOLD and MERIDIAN-SILVER; required starting on visit 1 under MERIDIAN-BRONZE and CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: 2 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Physical therapy initial evaluation, standardized functional outcome baseline measurements, and physician-signed plan of care. 4. Appeal Route: Rehabilitation Utilization Review Committee, with secondary appeal to the Director of Ancillary Services, Elena Rostova.

4.3.12 Routine Screening Mammography 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE, in accordance with federal preventive service mandates. 2. Approval Window: N/A (Exempt from pre-authorization). 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Standard screening requisition form. 4. Appeal Route: N/A.

4.3.13 Outpatient Diagnostic Cystoscopy 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE and CIVIC-BASE; not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD and MERIDIAN-SILVER. 2. Approval Window: 3 business days. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Urinalysis results, urine cytology reports, and clinical notes documenting persistent unexplained hematuria or lower urinary tract symptoms refractory to medical management. 4. Appeal Route: Urological Peer Review Panel, followed by review through the Meridian Member Grievance Board.

4.3.14 Stereotactic Radiosurgery (Outpatient) 1. Pre-Authorization Requirement: Required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, and CIVIC-BASE. 2. Approval Window: 5 business days for standard scheduling; 24 hours for oncological urgent cases. 3. Clinical Documentation Needed: Oncologic tumor board notes, recent volumetric contrast-enhanced MRI or CT imaging, and radiation oncology treatment planning records. 4. Appeal Route: Oncology Expert Panel Review, with expedited secondary appeal directly to the Chief Medical Officer, Dr. Aris Thorne.

4.4 Enforcement and Governance

4.4.1 Any procedure performed without pre-authorization where mandated shall be subject to a 100% contractual write-down by the operating facility at Meridian Health Partners site locations.

4.4.2 Exceptions to these pre-authorization requirements are restricted exclusively to documented medical emergencies where delay would result in imminent loss of life or limb, as verified by the attending emergency physician and countersigned by the on-duty utilization review coordinator.